Week 7 Teacher Guide: Faith Tests Across the Covenants

The Obedience of Faith, Week 7 of 12. Opens Unit III (Testing).

Companion to Week07-FaithTestsAcrossCovenants.pptx.

Scripture from the NET Bible.

Aim: Establish the pattern: every covenant era carries tests of faith, commanded or providential occasions where trust in God's word must become costly action.

What this week must accomplish (and nothing more): the class leaves able to (1) tell a *test* from a *temptation* (same event, opposite purposes) and (2) recognize the single shape that recurs in every covenant: *God speaks → faith must trust the word against sight → obedience makes the invisible visible.* And underneath both, one guardrail they must not lose: *the tests sit on the far side of grace.* If they leave thinking Unit III has quietly reintroduced salvation-by-performance, the week has failed no matter how good the survey was.

Read this first: the guardrail warning. You have spent Week 4 convincing the class that righteousness is a gift, not a wage. Now you open a three-week unit called "Testing." For some, the word alone will reactivate every works-righteousness reflex they've ever had (*so I do have to prove myself after all*). Head this off in the first sixty seconds and reinforce it at the end: **every test in this lecture comes after the rescue, never before it.** Israel was redeemed from Egypt and *then* tested in the wilderness. The tests prove and refine a faith that already rests on grace; they never purchase standing. Grace saves; testing proves. Say it early, say it late, and the whole unit stays safe.

Where this sits in the arc: Units I–II built the vocabulary (the Good, the four layers, sincerity's failure) and the method (Berean discernment, truth-anchored love). Unit III now shows the *mechanism God actually uses* to bring faith from invisible to visible (testing), and traces it from Eden to Christ to the church (next week). This week is the survey; Weeks 8–9 land it on us.

Presentation

Segment 1: Test, or Tempt? (0:00–8:00 · Slide 2)

Open with the guardrail (above), then teach the vocabulary, because the whole unit depends on it.

God tests (first click). Two Hebrew words: *nasah*: to prove, to put to the proof (the word in Gen 22:1, "God *tested* Abraham"); and *bachan*: to assay or refine, the metallurgist's word for testing ore to bring out pure metal (Prov 17:3; Ps 66:10). The Greek is *dokimazō*: to test *in order to approve.* This is

the crucial nuance: the goldsmith who assays gold *wants it to pass*. God's testing is aimed at *your good*: proving genuine faith and strengthening it. God tests toward life.

Satan tempts (second click). The Greek *peirazō* covers both "test" and "tempt": the *word* is neutral; the *intent* is everything. In the tempter's hands, the identical pressure aims to break, to make faith fail, to destroy. Same event; opposite purpose.

Same event, two sides (third click). This is the reconciling insight, and Scripture gives two clear cases. **Job**: one calamity, and the narrative shows us both control rooms: Satan intends ruin (Job 1–2), God intends vindication and a deeper knowing (Job 42:5). **Peter**: Jesus says "Satan has demanded to sift you like wheat, but I have prayed for you that your faith may not fail" (Luke 22:31–32); the very same sifting that Satan means for destruction, Christ's intercession turns into the making of Peter. God permits what the enemy intends for evil and bends it to proving.

God never tempts toward evil (fourth click). James 1:13 is the guardrail: "God cannot be tempted by evil, and he himself tempts no one." God may *test* (prove), but never *solicits sin*. Then land the sentence that ties Unit III back to Unit I: **a test is the scheduled occasion of sacrifice**: the appointed moment when invisible trust is asked to cost something and thereby becomes visible. Every test in the survey has that shape.

Transition: "With that distinction in hand, walk the whole Bible: every covenant has its tests."

Segment 2: A Pattern in Every Covenant (8:00–30:00 · Slide 3, the table)

The five eras appear as a grid, shown whole, so the class sees the *pattern* rather than five isolated stories. Roughly four minutes per era.

- **Eden** (Gen 2:16–17): teach the *genius* of it: the command cost almost nothing to keep. One forbidden tree in a garden full of permitted ones ("you may freely eat from *every* tree… but"). That near-costlessness is exactly what makes it a *pure* test of trust: there was no reason to obey except that God had said so, no benefit to obedience beyond the relationship itself. Note that Scripture doesn't use the word "test" here (be precise: say "the command *functioned* as a test"), but the structure is unmistakable, and the serpent's attack (Week 6) was on the word's authority.
- **Noah** (Heb 11:7): "warned about things not yet seen." A lifetime of labor, expense, and ridicule on the strength of a warning with no visible referent: no rain, no flood, nothing to point to. Faith across a decades-long gap between the word and its fulfillment. The obedience formula marks his pass: "Noah did all that God commanded him" (Gen 6:22).
- **Abraham** (Gen 22:1): the *first explicit* test in Scripture: "God tested Abraham." The class studied Moriah in Week 2 as the paradigm *sacrifice*; now show it as the paradigm *test*, and note that these are the same event, which is the whole point (a test is the occasion of sacrifice). The ask: surrender the promise itself.
- **Moses** (Ex 16:4; Deut 8:2): the shift the class most needs to see: under Moses, testing stops being episodic and becomes *stated covenant policy*. The manna was a daily test with the

reason attached: "so that I may test them: will they walk in my law or not?" (Ex 16:4), with a Sabbath test built in. Deut 8:2 is the unit's thesis verse (test "to see if you have it within you to keep his commandments"). And Deut 13:3: even a false prophet working real signs is a test: "the Lord your God is testing you to see if you love him with all your heart." A whole covenant structured as an examination.

- **Kings / Hezekiah** (2 Chr 32:31): the sobering one; introduce it here but *save its depth for discussion Q2*. After decades of exemplary faithfulness, when the Babylonian envoys came, "God left him alone to test him and to know what was in his heart"; Hezekiah, showing off his treasuries, failed. The test moved *inward*: not a commanded act now, but the heart's true condition surfacing when divine support was withdrawn.

The takeaway note (read last): one shape in every era: God speaks; faith is asked to trust the word against sight, appetite, fear, or delay; obedience makes the invisible faith visible. The eras change; the shape does not.

Transition: "Every human here was tested. Only One was tested at every point and passed."

Segment 3: Christ the Tested One (30:00–40:00 · Slide 4)

This segment is what keeps the unit from collapsing into moralism ("try harder to pass your tests"). Give it full weight.

Matthew 4:1–2 (first click). Note who does the leading: "led by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted." This test is God-ordained and Satan-administered: the Job pattern exactly. And the number is not incidental: forty days deliberately echoes Israel's forty years.

The parallel (second click, the box). Israel: forty years in the wilderness, tested, and *failed*: grumbling for bread, demanding signs, chasing other gods. Jesus: forty days in the wilderness, tested, and *passed*. And here is the detail that seals it: **every answer Jesus gives is quoted from Deuteronomy 6–8: the very passages that interpret Israel's wilderness testing.** "Man does not live by bread alone" (Deut 8:3) answers the hunger test. "Worship the Lord your God and serve only him" (Deut 6:13). "Do not put the Lord your God to the test" (Deut 6:16). He is not improvising; he is deliberately re-taking Israel's failed exam, from Israel's own textbook.

The true Israel (third click). Jesus stands in as the true Israel, the true Son, and passes the test the nation flunked: "tempted in every way just as we are, yet without sin" (Heb 4:15). Fully tested; never once failed.

Hebrews 5:8–9 (fourth click): the hinge of the entire unit. Handle the two hard phrases: "he *learned obedience* through what he suffered" does not mean he moved from disobedience to obedience (he never disobeyed); it means he learned *experientially*, in his humanity, what obedience *costs* when it's hard. "Being *perfected*" means completed, brought to his goal as our pioneer, not morally improved. And the payoff: the tested, perfected Son "became the source of eternal salvation to *all who obey*

him." That last phrase, obedience as the mark of those he saves, is the bridge into next week's church tests.

Transition: "So if Christ has already passed the decisive exam, where does that leave *our* tests?"

Segment 4: Proving, Not Probation (40:00–45:00 · Slide 5)

The hinge stated plainly (first click): Christ has taken the decisive exam (Adam's, Israel's, ours) and passed. So the believer's tests are no longer *probation to earn a standing*; they are the *proving and refining* of a faith that already rests on his finished work. Analogy that helps: a student who has already been admitted still does the coursework; it builds real strength, but it isn't deciding whether he's enrolled. Our tests build; they don't admit.

The exodus order (second click): the Week 4 keystone doing its Unit-III job.
Redeemed *first* (Passover blood, Red Sea), tested *second* (wilderness, Deut 8:2). This single sequence is what prevents the entire testing unit from becoming a ladder to climb. Say it as the guardrail it is.

James 1 / 1 Peter 1 (third click): you can only call a trial "pure joy" (James 1:2) if it isn't deciding your salvation. The refining fire (1 Pet 1:7) assumes the gold is *already yours*; you don't refine ore to find out whether you own it; you refine it because you do. Testing that produces "praise and glory when Jesus Christ is revealed" is the testing of the already-redeemed.

The banner (fourth click): "Grace saves. Testing proves. Mercy first, altar second." The unit's motto. Say it, then move to discussion.

Segments 5–6: Discussion and Close (45:00–57:00 · Slides 6–7)

Q1: "Why does God test people He already knows completely?" He does know (Ps 139), so the test is not for *his* information. It's for three other purposes: **self-knowledge** (Deut 8:2, "to know what was in your heart": the test shows *you* what you're made of; cf. Week 1, devotion is invisible even to its owner until something makes it visible), **witness** (faith proven under pressure testifies to a watching world), and **actualization** (the test converts latent faith into a real event, an accomplished obedience on the record). The goldsmith knows the gold is gold; the fire still turns *latent* purity into *manifest* purity. God tests to make real and visible what he already knows is there.

Q2: "What did Hezekiah's being 'left alone' reveal that forty good years had not?" The tender, personal one: handle slowly, because someone in the room is *in* such a season now. Decades of faithful crisis-management (Hezekiah was superb under external threat (Assyria, illness)) had never surfaced the pride, because pride hides in success. It took *withdrawal* (God stepping back, the flattering envoys arriving, no immediate pressure) for what was really in his heart to leak out. The lesson: **felt divine absence can itself be the test.** Seasons when God seems silent are not always

discipline and not always abandonment; sometimes the silence *is* the exam: what do you reach for, boast in, or trust when the props are removed? Ask gently: "What leaks out of you when God seems quiet?" Then reassure: a season of silence for a faithful believer is often the refining fire, not a verdict of rejection.

The close (slide 7, ~2 min). Next week narrows from covenant tests in general to the *church's* specific tests. Reading: Acts 2:36–41 (the crowd asks "what shall we do?": the entry test) and 1 Corinthians 11:23–29 (find "examine": the recurring test at the table). Both flagged. Preview Week 8. Carry sentence: say it together. Close on Hebrews 5:9, which hands directly to next week's "all who obey him." Dismiss on time.

Answers to Questions You May Get

"If God tests toward good and Satan tempts toward evil, and it's the same event: who's really in control?" God, decisively. Job shows the structure: Satan can act only within God's permission ("the LORD said to Satan, 'very well then, everything he has is in your power'"; Job 1:12), and God overrules the intended ruin toward a greater end. Satan is real and malicious, but he is on a leash; he never gets the last word or the controlling purpose. This is enormous pastoral comfort: the trial that feels like the enemy's victory is, for the believer, being bent by God toward proving and glory (Rom 8:28).

"Doesn't testing imply God is unsure how we'll respond? That challenges his omniscience." No, and Q1 above is your answer. God's testing is never information-gathering; he "knows the heart" (1 Kgs 8:39) and declares "the end from the beginning" (Isa 46:10). The test is *for us*: to make faith real, visible, and strong, and to reveal us to ourselves. When Genesis 22:12 says "*now* I know that you fear God," it's covenant-disclosure language: the tested obedience is now an accomplished, public fact, not God acquiring a datum he lacked.

"How do I tell whether a hard season is God testing me, Satan attacking me, or discipline for sin?" Often you can't tell in the moment, and Scripture rarely asks you to diagnose the *source*: it asks you to respond the same way regardless: trust, obey, endure, repent of any actual sin the Spirit surfaces, and hold to Christ. Job never learned about the heavenly wager. The response to a test and the response to an attack are identical from your side: cling to the word against sight. If clear sin is involved, treat it as discipline and repent (Heb 12); if not, treat it as proving and endure (James 1). Either way the medicine is faith.

"Is it wrong to pray 'lead us not into temptation' if God tests us for our good?" Not at all; Jesus taught us to pray exactly that (Matt 6:13), and it's a prayer of humility: *Lord, don't bring me to the testing-point relying on my own strength; I know how weak I am.* It's the opposite of presumption. Peter was confident he'd never fail and was sifted; the humble prayer is "spare me the trial I'm not ready for, and if it comes, hold my faith fast," which is precisely what Christ prayed *for* Peter (Luke 22:32). Wanting to be tested is pride; asking to be kept is wisdom.

"Did Jesus really *need* to be tested if he couldn't sin?" The testing was real, whatever we conclude about its outcome's certainty. Hebrews insists he was "tempted in every way just as we are" (4:15) and "learned obedience through what he suffered" (5:8): the pressure was genuine, the hunger real, the cost actual. The value of his passing isn't diminished by its certainty any more than a diamond's hardness is diminished by the certainty it won't shatter. And the point for us is representative: he passed the exam humanity kept failing, *as our substitute and pioneer*, so that our tests are now the proving of people already counted righteous in him.

Prep Checklist

- [ ] Read Deuteronomy 8:1–10 whole: the thesis verse in its context (note the "he humbled you… to test you" logic)
- [ ] Read Matthew 4:1–11 alongside Deuteronomy 6–8, tracing each of Jesus' quotes to its source
- [ ] Read 2 Chronicles 32:24–31: Hezekiah's whole arc, so the "left alone" test lands with its context
- [ ] Read Luke 22:31–32 and Job 1–2 so the "same event, two sides" cases are at your fingertips
- [ ] Be ready to distinguish *nasah / bachan / dokimazō* simply, without a Greek lecture
- [ ] Rehearse the era table against the clock (~4 min/era; Moses and Hezekiah carry the most)
- [ ] Print/post next week's reading with both flags ("what shall we do" / "examine")

If You Run Long

Cut in this order: compress the Noah and Abraham rows on slide 3 (both were studied earlier; one line each) to give Moses and Hezekiah room; trim the three Deuteronomy quotes in the Christ parallel box to two (keep Deut 8:3, the bread answer); hold the James/1 Peter click on slide 5 (the banner carries the point). **Never cut:** the test/tempt distinction on slide 2, the Israel/Jesus parallel on slide 4, the exodus-order click on slide 5, or the grace banner. If discussion must shrink, keep Q1 (it answers the omniscience objection that will otherwise nag people) and let Q2 run informally; Q2 is the more pastorally valuable, so protect it if you can.